

Field Notebook — Ashanti Music Survey

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Collector: J. H. Kwabena Nketia

Period of survey: 1954 – 1956

1. General observations

The Adowa ensemble encountered at Mampong comprises the atumpan (talking drums), petia, apentemma, and the dawuro bell. The bell maintains the time-line against which all other instruments are read. Field measurements of the drum pitches were taken by ear and cross-checked with a monochord.

2. On the talking drums

The atumpan reproduce the tonal contours of Twi speech. Appellations of the paramount stool were recorded and transcribed in situ; a preliminary drum-language notation appears on the facing leaf. Informants confirmed that the opening phrase invokes the ancestral smiths of the drum.

Transcription Notes

3. Rhythmic organisation

The supporting drums articulate a two-bar response against the bell timeline.

The master drum (atumpan) improvises within the metric frame, signalling the dancers with recurring cadential figures. A schematic of the interlocking pattern is entered below in the collector's shorthand.

bell	x	.	x	.	x	x	.	x	.	x	.	x
petia	.	x	.	x	.	x	.	x	.	x	.	x
apen	x	.	.	x	.	.	x	.	.	x	.	.
master	~ improvised, cued to dance ~											

4. Recording particulars

Machine: portable 1/4" reel-to-reel. Tape speed 7.5 ips. Two microphones, one on the master drum, one overhead. Ambient conditions noted as dry; the durbar ground was open, giving a short natural reverberation.

Catalogue & Cross-references

5. Related holdings

- IAS/AU/0012 Adowa Ensemble, Mampong-Ashanti (audio)
- IAS/PH/00214 Adowa Dancer at a Durbar (photograph)
- IAS/MS/0009 Field Notebook, present volume

6. Notes for the archive

This transcript is a working document and should be read alongside the original sound recording. Spellings of place and personal names follow the collector's usage of the period and have not been silently modernised.

— End of selected leaves —

This is a representative, digitised sample prepared for demonstration within the J. H. Kwabena Nketia Archives online finding aid.